

I Want to Hear Them

By Tomas Rodriguez

1 INT. INTERROGATION ROOM - UNKNOWN

ROGER, a lad in his early 20s, who has a stronger heart than his stone faced demeanor shows. He is wearing clothes almost akin to hospital scrubs and staring down at the blank table in front of him.

WOMAN (O.S.)
Where is Argus Ibsen?

ROGER doesn't move a muscle, his gaze never leaving the table.

WOMAN (O.S.) (CONT'D)
You left together, and only you came back. How do you explain that?
(a beat)
There was no body, no car, nothing. Just you, all dazed and confused.

ROGER
(looking down at the table)
I can't remember.

WOMAN (O.S.)
You have to remember something.
(a beat)
You drove all the way out to the middle of nowhere to do god knows what. Did you want to kill him. Would be quite the place to do it. No prying eyes.
(a beat)
Even the ambulance found no signs. Except for tracks on the ground.

ROGER lifts his gaze, not a trace of emotion in his sunken visage. He gazes blankly at the woman off-screen.

CUT TO:

2 EXT. BARREN DESERT - DAY

A large SUV is parked in the middle of the desert. Nothing in sight but the pale yellow shades of the desert.

ARGUS, a lad about the same age as ROGER, with a conviction stronger than his muscles, is taking things out of the trunk of the car. A black briefcase, radio antenna, and a tripod. ROGER stands to the side of the car watching ARGUS.

ROGER
No, no, no. Not this again.

ARGUS is too concentrated on setting up the equipment to respond.

ROGER (CONT'D)
Come on Argus. I want spend time with you, not be your lab assistant.

ARGUS
Trust me, this time it will work.

ROGER
Then what do you call what happened last time? You where four miles deep in the middle of the woods.

ROGER crosses his arms and stares at ARGUS, annoyance building in his eyes.

ROGER (CONT'D)
You need to stop this obsession.

ARGUS
I'm sure with enough data I can get that scholarship this time.

ROGER
You don't care about the scholarship.

ARGUS doesn't respond, continues setting up his equipment.

ROGER (CONT'D)
I haven't seen you in almost six months. Did you ever stop to think I missed you?

ARGUS
I did too, but I need to do this. It's now or never.

ROGER
You'll have plenty of time to listen other times. I leave for Brown this fall.

ARGUS turns around, gazing at ROGER with soft eyes.

ARGUS
I'm sorry Rog. I didn't mean to trick
(MORE)

ARGUS (CONT'D)

you.

(a beat)

I didn't think you would agree if you knew.

ROGER

Yeah, I probably would not have.

The two look at each other in a silent duel of wills. ARGUS gives ROGER a hint of a smile.

ARGUS

How 'bout this. You help me out, max one hour, then we leave and on the way back we stop at The Apple Pan.

ARGUS tilts his head and raises his eyebrows as if saying - *"how does that sound"*.

ARGUS (CONT'D)

I know you want to go.

ROGER stares at ARGUS.

ROGER

Something else.

ARGUS

Please.

ROGER ponders for a while. He says with love for his friend -

ROGER

(apprehensive)

Fine. 30 minutes.

(a beat)

And you're paying for food.

ARGUS

Ok, but 50 minutes.

ROGER

40 or nothing.

ARGUS

(with a small smile)

Deal. 40 minutes.

ROGER takes out his phone showing the screen to ARGUS.

ARGUS (CONT'D)
Let's get goin' then.

ROGER walks over to antenna, putting his hands around the dish, giving ARGUS an "*I'm ready*" stare. ARGUS turns on the machine. The graph on the computer screen lights up looking like short grass at the bottom of the display.

ARGUS (CONT'D)
Let's run base tones.
(a beat)
One.

ROGER points the antenna to the sky. A BEAT

ARGUS (CONT'D)
Two.

ROGER points the antenna down to the ground. A BEAT

ARGUS (CONT'D)
Set.

ROGER once again aims the antenna at the sky.

ARGUS puts on some large headphones, placing one hand on the side as if pressing a comms button. ROGER walks over to the car and takes out a folding chair, opening it and sitting down.

ROGER takes out his notebook and begins to doodle. The two sit in silence, like fishermen awaiting something - anything.

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ROGER
(not looking up from his notebook)
Did you get those cute crocodile
gummies I sent you?

The graph on the computer screen begins spiking. There is no response from ARGUS; we only see him from the back at this point. Every so often there are ARGUS twitches slightly.

ROGER (CONT'D)

I must have tried like eight times to send you stuff and everything got rejected. Only those gummies made it through. They must have been sick of me after the number of times I called.

(Roger drones on)

No stringy things... no metal thingys... no things with handles... so many noes. Like come on.

ROGER looks up, hoping Argus was paying attention.

ROGER (CONT'D)

Argus?

(a beat)

(in a louder tone)

Planet Earth to Argus... anybody up there?

ARGUS hasn't moved a muscle save the twitches. ROGER walks up to him and takes the headset off his head.

ROGER (CONT'D)

Argus, are you deaf.

For a second ARGUS's body remains frozen until - uah! He snaps awake.

ARGUS

Hey? Did you say something?

ROGER recognizes his friends pale expression.

ROGER

It's happening again isn't it?

ARGUS

No, no. I was just super concentrated. Sorry, totally missed what you said.

ROGER

Let's go get burgers.

ARGUS

What'd you say?

ROGER

I said we are done. Let's go.

ROGER tugs at ARGUS's arm.

ARGUS

No, please. Gimme a little more time.
I'm collecting some really good data.

ROGER

Ohh really!? Because from over here it
looks like all you do is stare at that
goddamn screen like it's giving away
candy.

ARGUS

With this stuff I'm sure I'll get the
scholarship.

ROGER

(angered)

You don't give a flying fuck about the
scholarship. You just want to listen
to whatever strange sounds come
through those headphone.

ARGUS

That's not true.

ROGER

Then why did you record the sounds
from last time?

ARGUS

To keep as recorded evidence.

ROGER

You would listen to it almost
everyday. You even asked me to send it
to you in the hospital.

ARGUS is left speechless.

ARGUS

It calms me dow-

ROGER cuts him off before he can continue.

ROGER

You're stopping right now. I am not
about let you be taken away for who
(MORE)

ROGER (CONT'D)
knows how long.

ARGUS
(in defeat)
Give me a few more minutes to listen.

ROGER sighs. He's done with all this bullshit.

ROGER
If you want to go mad you can do that
yourself. I'm leaving.

ROGER turns around and storms towards the car. ARGUS watches ROGER storm off towards the car, he shrugs - not really a problem for him. He turns around and looks towards his computer screen and grabs his headphones.

ROGER storms back with a water bottle in hand, opens it and dumps half of it on a black box labeled SDR.

ARGUS
What the fuck!

ARGUS attempts frantically to mop up the spill with his shirt.

ROGER
I missed you Argie. I truly did.

ROGER turns around for the last time and storms off towards the car.

ROGER (CONT'D)
(looking away from ARGUS)
Call me when you actually want to
hangout. If you even make it out of
this desert.

ROGER gets in the car and drives away. The computer still seems to be receiving signals even with the damaged radio.

ARGUS kneels in front of the computer, like a junkie ready for his next high and places the headphones on. We see him from the back only. We stay on him for a while, everything is still.

. . .

ARGUS begins to have small twitches as time progresses.

Moments later we hear the sound of a car pulling up and stopping. Somebody steps out of the car. ROGER walks over to ARGUS.

ROGER (CONT'D)
I'm not gonna let you hurt yourself.
We are leaving. Now.

ROGER touches him and ARGUS collapses sideways towards the ground. His eyes are bleeding and his lips bone dry. ROGER checks his pulse, and puts his ear too his mouth.

He dials 911, someone on the other end picks up.

ROGER (CONT'D)
My friend is unconscious and faintly
breathing. His eyes are bleeding. I
need help. Please! Hurry!

The other side of the line says something, we can't hear it.

ROGER (CONT'D)
I don't know where we are. Somewhere
around Joshua Tree National Park.
Can't you track this call?

ARGUS listens for the response and hangs up the phone.

ROGER picks ARGUS up, hugs him, and begins rocking him back and forth. ROGER whispers under his breath "I'm sorry, I'm so sorry."

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After a while, ROGER begins to looks over at the computer screen, graph still pulsing. In morbid curiosity about the cause of his friends condition he lays ARGUS's body down and puts on the headphones.

Almost instantly his eyes shoot up into his skull. His body begins convulsing before it suddenly freezes. A few moments later he stands up, his back to us. He walks off into the vast and lonely desert. His pace steady and never wavering.

CUT TO:

3 INT. INTERROGATION ROOM - UNKNOWN

ROGER glares at the WOMAN off-screen.

WOMAN (O.S.)
Why did you call the ambulance?

ROGER
I heard their voices. They spoke of
such wonderful things.

WOMAN (O.S.)
Where did you hear these... voices?

ROGER
They told me they would bring me
peace.

WOMAN (O.S.)
(in a demanding tone)
Your not answering anything Mr.
Tennyson. I am gonna ask you one last
time where is Argus Ibsen?

ROGER
I want to listen again. Let me.
Please!

WOMAN (O.S.)
Mr. Tennyson I am not playing games
here. You are going to be put on trial
for this and I'll make damn sure you
do not win.

ROGER
They help me breath unrestrained.

The sound of dialing is heard, then a phone ringing.

WOMAN (O.S.)
Hey Chavez. I'm done here with Mr.
Tennyson. Call and see if Alhambra
Hospital has room for another.

ROGER
I don't want to live without their
voices. You don't understand.

THE END

